

The cost of holding the front line

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By MAX GRIERA GOOD MONDAY

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GOOD MONDAY MORNING. This is Max Griaer, EU politics reporter, with a big welcome to our new colleagues at POLITICO Australia . More on that in a moment.

PLAYBOOK ON THE ROAD: I'm writing to you from Riga airport — the first stop on a week-long tour of five capitals where I'll be looking at the political pressures building beyond the Brussels bubble and what they mean for decisions made inside it.

From Riga to The Hague, Madrid, Bratislava and Budapest, we'll dig into how economic strain, security fears, climate policies and a resurgent far right are shifting the political ground across Europe. (Plus: Playbook's mini travel guide for each capital.) Let's go!

In today's Playbook:

- Latvia is seeking EU cash and private investment to shore up struggling Baltic rail and air networks.
- Kaja Kallas is eyeing the biggest Russia sanctions package yet, as Riga pushes for a blanket visa ban.
- Faces in the crowd: Andris Kulbergs, Kaja Kallas, Ainars Šlesers, Andris Šuvajevs, Thomas Byrne, George Soros, Andrejs Žagars, Dan Jørgensen and more.

DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — FRONTLINE FATIGUE: Latvia's prime minister wants Brussels to put up €7 billion to help cover the costs of living on Russia's doorstep — just as parties arguing for a softer line on Moscow gain ground ahead of the country's Oct. 3 election.

On the ground in Riga, Russia's war feels much closer than it does in Brussels: Ukrainian flags line the streets and fly high on the buildings. With the border just a few hours east, Latvia has sharply increased its defense spending since the full-scale invasion over four years ago, while commerce that once tied its economy to Russia has been badly hit by sanctions and a collapse in bilateral trade. And the strain is starting to show.

The ask: Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs told Playbook at the government chancellery that Latvia should get the extra €7 billion from the next seven-year EU budget, under the proposed Competitiveness Fund, to help cover both its higher defense costs and the economic fallout from severing ties with Russia. The cash, which Latvia wants on top of other funds earmarked for the country, would represent almost half of Latvia's projected €15.12 billion defense bill over the same period.

Who's paying: Kulbergs' argument is that Latvia is borrowing to provide security for countries much farther from the front line. "We are getting our budget deficit to the maximum ... and from that debt we're paying ... the defense of the whole Europe," he said. Much of that spending, he added, flows back west through arms purchases from Germany, France, Spain, Sweden and the Netherlands. "We fuel their economies."

A harder version: The same grievance is surfacing on the campaign trail. Ainārs Šlesers, the veteran populist businessman whose party sits with the far-right Patriots for Europe, said Latvia should demand compensation when it backs EU sanctions on Russia. He condemns Moscow's invasion and says support for Ukraine should continue, but argues Riga can no longer treat the economic cost as open-ended.

No blank check: "We are losing money ... we are talking about how to support Ukraine, but we are a victim," Šlesers told Playbook at his campaign HQ in Riga. When sanctions come up for renewal, he said, Latvia should "get in return support." Asked whether that could mean withholding Latvia's backing, he fell short of threatening a veto, but he would not rule it out: "I don't want to talk about [a] veto [now], I guess that we ... will find a peaceful solution."

Election math: Center-right Kulbergs leads the polls, but the coalition math could still soften Latvia's Russia line. While the far-right, pro-Russia Sovereign Power (polling second) is considered untouchable by the mainstream, Kulbergs has left the door open to governing with right-wing populist Šlesers, whose party is polling third.

Progressives' warning: The center-left Progressives, polling fourth and hoping to govern with Kulbergs, warn that bringing in Šlesers would dilute Latvia's hard-line Russia stance. "I'm 100 percent sure Latvia's foreign policy towards Russia is going to soften over time," through sanctions exemption on some Russian businessmen and with some ministers "speaking in a more friendly tone towards Russia," the party's PM candidate Andris Šuvajevs told Playbook outside parliament.

After October: Latvia remains one of Europe's staunchest Ukraine backers. But the election is exposing a growing clash over how long the country can keep absorbing the economic and military costs of confronting Russia — and how much it should demand from the rest of Europe in return.

BIG AND BREAKING

NUCLEAR SAFETY SCARE: A Russian state-controlled corporation building a nuclear power plant in Hungary is facing allegations of safety failures at another project in Egypt that uses the same technology, according to internal documents obtained by our Canadian energy wonk Ben Makuch.

SURPRISE FOR SEOUL: Donald Trump posted on Truth Social last night that he's ordered the Pentagon to scale back military exercises with South Korea, citing the cost and his "very good relationship" with North Korea's Kim Jong Un.

BREXIT RESET: Irish EU Affairs Minister Thomas Byrne is in London today, where he'll discuss plans for a second U.K.-EU summit in the "near future" with Britain's new Europe Minister Hamish Falconer,

Byne's office said.

PARMESAN UNDER PRESSURE: Italy's scorching summer is squeezing its €4 billion Parmigiano Reggiano industry, with overheated cows producing less milk; electricity costs soaring as farmers run fans and sprinklers almost nonstop; and drought restricting supplies of local cattle feed. Our Rome correspondent Hannah Roberts breaks it down.

BALTIC BILLS

THE PRICE OF STAYING CONNECTED: Latvia wants at least €4 billion from the next EU budget to finish its stretch of Rail Baltica — the line meant to tie the Baltic states more tightly to the rest of Europe and move troops and military equipment quickly in a crisis to NATO's eastern flank.

The project's troubles are hard to miss in Riga. Outside the airport, an imposing concrete structure meant to be a station stands unfinished; in the city center, a half-built bridge looms over the river. "For many people this is the embodiment of how badly the Rail Baltica project has been run," the Progressives' Šuvajevs told Playbook, standing beneath it.

Costs have exploded: Rail Baltica is supposed to connect Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania to Poland and Western Europe by 2030. But its estimated cost has jumped from €5.8 billion in 2017 to €23.8 billion, forcing the project to be split into phases and ambitions scaled back.

Cost-cutting: Prime Minister Kulbergs is openly doubtful the project's 2030 deadline can be met. "We have to scale back all the nice wishes," he said. He also called Lithuania and Estonia's cost assumptions "unachievable," joking they would make the "Guinness Book of Records" if they delivered at those prices.

Message to Brussels: Kulbergs says Latvia needs a "minimum" of €4 billion from the next EU budget to complete Latvia's stretch of the track. The Commission says there will be no dedicated pot, and Rail Baltica will have to compete for cash from the proposed €51.5 billion Connecting Europe Facility and other EU funds.

Latvia's connectivity strains also extend to the air.

State-controlled airBaltic, one of the Baltics' main links to the rest of Europe, is under financial pressure after years of losses — and the government is grappling with how to save it without splurging more taxpayers' cash. Kulbergs said he would consider selling the state's 89 percent stake to a foreign buyer, alongside shrinking the airline or bringing in a strategic investor: "All the options are on the table."

The bigger bind: Europe wants the Baltics better connected and better defended. Riga's message, on rail as on security, is that the price is rising faster than Latvia is willing — or able — to carry alone.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

RUSSIAN VISAS

THE NEXT RUSSIA SANCTIONS PUSH: EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas says she will put forward "the most far-reaching sanctions list since the beginning of the war" this fall, expanding the number of sanctioned individuals, businesses and other entities by a third, she told German newspaper WELT

(which is owned by Axel Springer, POLITICO's parent company).

The visa fight: Reopening sanctions talks is set to reignite a clash over which Russians Europe should let in. During negotiations on the 21st package, France and Italy resisted a blanket ban on Russian combatants, arguing visas should be handled under EU visa rules rather than sanctions, while northern and eastern countries pushed for tougher restrictions. The eventual deal created the legal and political basis for barring combatants and ex-combatants who took part in the war — leaving it up to the Council to decide when the ban takes effect.

“Are we nuts?!” was Latvian PM Kallaugra's take on the delay. “We allow Russian military soldiers to be given visas, the ones killing [Ukrainians] on the field,” he told Playbook in Riga, adding that his office is pushing for a blanket ban on visas for all Russian citizens — not only military personnel. While the bloc tightened rules on Russian visas in 2022, over 600,000 were issued by EU countries in 2025.

Playbook came to Brussels in 2015 and changed how this town starts its day. It has now landed in Canberra: a capital with just as many officials and, until now, no daily briefing of its own. Canberra Playbook: free, daily, radically impartial. Subscribe free .

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

A DRONE'S JOURNEY: Business Insider (part of the Axel Springer Global Reporters Network) tracked a surveillance drone from a factory on the Welsh coast to the front lines of southeastern Ukraine, showing how uncrewed aircraft are reshaping combat and how Western companies are adapting rapidly to lessons from the battlefield.

PROTECTING POLITICIANS: Germany's political parties agree that a controversial law against insulting politicians needs an overhaul, after recent investigations into people who mocked Friedrich Merz as “Pinocchio” and “Lying Fritz” — but not on how to fix it, Ferdinand Knapp reports.

TODAY IN JERUSALEM ... Donald Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner will meet Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to push the Board of Peace's Gaza plan, which Israel rejected last week. That's after Kushner met the head of Hamas in Cairo Sunday.

BATTLE FOR THE CITY: Britain's Conservatives are plotting to win back London as PM Andy Burnham shifts Labour's focus toward the cost-of-living crisis and regions outside the capital, Hannah Brenton writes.

ABOUT THAT AUSSIE SOCIAL MEDIA BAN ... My new colleagues in Canberra bust some of the myths about Australia's teen social media restrictions that are being closely watched by politicians in the EU and elsewhere.

RIGA CORNER

WHERE THE COOL KIDS HANG: To kick off our mini-series of top political and cultural hotspots on this week's capitals road trip, I went to catch up with a journalist friend at postmodern Café Osiris — Riga's longest-running continuously operating restaurant/bar.

The cafe opened in 1994 after Latvia split from the Soviet Union with financing from George Soros' Open Society Foundations, with Soros himself attending the inaugural dinner. Initially run by Andrejs

Žagars, who later became director of the Latvian National Opera, it became a haunt for Latvian and international artists and queer icons, just meters from the New Riga Theatre.

The venue's first dinner was attended by prominent political, business and cultural figures including Andris Piebalgs, a European commissioner for development under President José Manuel Barroso. Each dish was named after a political party contesting that year's local elections. Thirty-two years later, every one of those parties is gone, but Osiris still stands. Check out its history [here](#).

A SOBERING STOP: Between interviews, I headed to Riga's former KGB headquarters for one of the city's most chilling tours. We squeezed through tiny cells where dozens of political prisoners were crammed together before ending in the garage used for executions — its walls once lined with plastic, a drain in the floor to wash away the blood, bullet holes still visible today. Tickets and info [.](#)

TRAVEL TIP: If you're visiting and it's warm, I'd recommend taking the 30-minute train from Riga Central to Majori and plunging into the Baltic sea at Jūrmala beach. On the way back, make sure to stop at Riga Central Market for some pīrāgi, bacon-filled pastry rolls.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Rain changing to sunny intervals later in the day. High 23C.

G'DAY FROM CANBERRA: Australia may not be the EU's 28th member, but it's getting closer — part of Europe's conversations on China, critical minerals, energy security, climate policy, trade and democratic resilience. POLITICO Australia is now live, and the first edition of Canberra Playbook is out [.](#) Led by Brussels Playbook's original author, Ryan Heath, the team will take you inside the political decisions shaping Australia's positions, with calm, clear reporting on the people and institutions behind them. Sign up [here](#) [.](#)

DAN JUAN'S SUMMER OF LOVE: Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen might have drawn the short straw by having to stay in Brussels while his colleagues are away, but he's not missing out on the heat. The Dane introduced his new girlfriend on social media over the weekend, including with a saucy snap from Ixelles' Cocq Frit, Playbook's Gabriel Gavin writes in.

BELGIUM'S WORST WILDFIRE: Roughly 3,000 hectares have burned in the Hautes Fagnes in eastern Wallonia since a blaze broke out on Friday, forcing some 600 people to evacuate and making it the largest wildfire in Belgium's recorded history [.](#)

SECRET SPOTS: The Hide & Seek Festival kicks off a run of 11 concerts in the city's most unusual and rarely accessible venues, including a tram depot, the town hall of Ixelles, the ballroom of the Council of State, a Buddhist center and the Cercle Royal Gaulois. Through Saturday. Program and tickets [.](#)

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Germany suspects Russia was behind the Leipzig drone attack but is holding back for now.

Canberra: PM Anthony Albanese turned to one of his Labor predecessors, Paul Keating, for advice on how to juggle Australia's relationships with the U.S. and China.

London: Andy Burnham inadvertently exchanged messages with someone posing as White House chief of staff Susie Wiles, setting off a security scare.

Paris: PM Sébastien Lecornu will visit wildfire victims today to show his government is in control — but it's more ammunition for those who think he's eyeing a run for president.

Washington: Democrats have been racked by high-profile primaries pitting left against center, but some candidates are offering a different path — leaning in to working-class populism.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Alexandr Vondra, Christian Ehler, Victor Negrescu and Jaroslava Pokorná Jermanová; Liberty's Akiko Hart; Estonian Ambassador to NATO Jüri Luik; Belgian diplomat Maite Morren; European Commission's Enrico Forti.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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